

May: The 8086

The Intel 8086 processor, the first processor to join the x86 architecture families of processors, was released. The complete 16-bit architecture of 8086 had 16-internal registers, a 16-bit data bus, and a 20-bit address bus. Intel later released the Intel 8088, an 8-bit version, which was also used in the original IBM PC.

The 8086 was known as 16-bit processor as all its internal registers, internal data buses, and external data buses were 16 bits wide. (Registers are the processor's local storage area used to hold the data while it is being worked on by the processor. The internal data bus is what carries data internally within the CPU circuit, and it communicates among the internal memory caches of the CPU.)

Its clock frequency was originally limited to 5 MHz, and later versions of the CPU were manufactured using HMOS (High performance n-channel Metal-Oxide Semiconductor) technology specified for 10 MHz. The 8086 instruction set included a power set of a few instructions.

June: *Space Invaders*—And More

The popular arcade game *Space Invaders*, designed by Tomohiro Nishikado who worked as an engineer in Taito Corp., was released. It used an Intel 8080 processor that ran at 2 MHz. It is said that the look of the aliens were devised based on H G Wells' science-fiction story *The War of the Worlds*.

The original version of the game had monochrome video images; later, Taito added coloured bands on the reflective screen. *Space Invaders* became popular due to its unique game-play—unlike other clock-timed video games, it was life-based.

The Beginning...

The first commercial computer built on an 8086 was the Mycron 2000. Also, IBM's Displaywriter word processing system, the Wang Professional Computer, AT&T 6300 PC, and the first Compaq Deskpro were based on the 8086 chip.